

CHENNAI • Thursday, March 12, 2026



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THE HINDU

Don't fear snakes, say Rom and Zai Whitaker in their new book for young readers **P2**

PRIYANKA MOHAN'S
KOREAN SOJOURN **P4**



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“Only coffee and tea today,” says a sign taped to the counter at Bangalore Thindis on Bengaluru’s Infantry Road, which normally bustles with customers. In Coimbatore, Annapoorna Hotel has taken rava dosas off the menu. At Kaylir Canteen in Chennai, co-founder Dhanya Srinath explains their shorter menu on Instagram saying, “We are trying to be a space that never pauses operations during situations like this... the options will be limited, but it will be yummy.”

Hoteliers, chefs and restaurateurs are in firefighting mode as they figure out how to make their existing fuel last for as long as possible and keep customers fed, till there is some clarity on how to move forward.

The conflict in West Asia continues, and its effects can be felt in cities across India. On Monday (March 9, 2026) LPG cylinder supply was restricted in several cities. The Bangalore Hotels Association put out a notice saying that if the supply is not resumed, hotels may have to shut down.

Although prices have been moving upwards for the past two weeks, by an estimated 40%, according to Chennai-based Japtej Ahluwalia, co-founder, BORN (Beyond Ordinary Restaurants and Nosh) and a managing committee member, NRAI (National Restaurant Association of India), they were managing to source cylinders. The seven restaurants BORN runs across the city, including Sortd, Fufu and Double Roti, require around 20 to 25 cylinders a day.

LPG as the backbone

The effect is being felt all through the country. Zorawar Kalra, founder, Massive Restaurants, which runs brands like Masala Library, Pa Pa Ya and Farzi Cafe explains that commercial LPG is the backbone of kitchen operations across India, and any disruption threatens the continuity of food service for millions.

He adds, “The restaurant industry is a ₹6.6-lakh-crore ecosystem and a major employer, and it is critical that policy clarity ensures LPG supply. A single day’s lack of supply will cost the industry and the economy between 1,200-1,300 crores as 70-75% of the ecosystem relies on LPG.”

Sources from the F&B industry



Why are dosas off the menu?

With commercial LPG supply restricted across India, restaurants are rationing fuel, trimming menus and shortening hours. Can induction stoves, sigris and willpower get them through this weekend?



say that cylinders were available for about double the market price till recently. Now, though restaurants are willing to buy them at any price, all sources seem to have dried up.

Will induction work?

Santhosh Zachariah, of Chennai’s speakeasy MadCo, which usually opens at noon, says they are now only opening for dinner to conserve their LPG cylinders and cutting out dishes that require higher flames, and longer cook times, like their popular bone marrow. “Induction is not an alternative for a lot of the cooking we do,” he says, adding “also our electricity bills will go through the roof.”

Naga Bharan who spearheads five outlets of Panchakattu Dosa across Hyderabad is also unenthusiastic about induction. “The change requires a complete

overhaul in infrastructure, including our electrical work,” he says.

He adds, “We are working towards optimising our resources; for instance we are running one dosa stove instead of two. We are informing customers that orders might be slightly delayed. No stove is allowed to run idle anymore. Earlier our dosa stoves used to be kept on in anticipation of orders.”

Changes on the menu

Japtej says, “We are working on optimising menus across restaurants; high gas consumption items like Asian woks or even pizzas are being limited and our focus is on conserving our existing gas reserves as much as possible for weekend operations which contributes to nearly 40% of our revenue.”

Wherever possible, equipment swaps are also being explored.

Japtej says they are replacing burger griddles that run on gas with electric equipment which they are temporarily renting.

Businesses are also looking at temporarily tweaking their menu. Sampath T of Spicy Venue in Hyderabad, who is also a member of NRAI, says, “We are looking to push more dishes that do not require long usage of LPG. While biryani cannot be skipped, we are looking at stir-fried in place of deep-fried Indian side dishes for the time being.”

While running costs are going up, most restaurants are absorbing the difference in prices without passing them on to the customers. Vinay Gopal Manik Pradeep, manager, Mana Biryani Vindu located on the busy MVP Double Road in Visakhapatnam, says, “We would rather shut down than increase prices. We are planning to make

only biryanis for now and stop serving fried items.”

While the supply has not been affected in Delhi, Radhika Khandelwal, chef-founder behind restaurants such as Trouble Trouble and Kona Sandwich Shop says they are preparing alternatives. “Even if we have four induction stoves, it is not equal to the 10-burner gas range we have. We also have grills and pizza ovens which require gas,” she says. The Government had also cracked down on coal- and firewood-based tandors in Delhi-NCR to curb pollution.

This is affecting everyone from luxury hotels in the country’s swankiest cities to tea stalls. R Parthasarathy has been a restaurateur for more than 35 years running Hotel Sri Ranga in Salem for two decades. “We have had bad times collectively as the hotel industry before, but this shortage of commercial cylinders is new,” he says, adding “I am now managing lunch on wood fire, but for dinner and breakfast, I require the cylinder for dosa and parotta.”

Meanwhile Chef Chindi Varadarajulu of Pumpkin Tales and Zhoyu in Chennai is finding energy effective ways to cook. “Our breads are cooked in an electric oven, and we have bought some charcoal powered stoves for staff meals and to cook the large base sauces, then we can use induction stove to finish up.” She says she is also firing up a new sigri: “We are thinking of going back to the old style of cooking.”

In Coimbatore, iconic Annapoorna Hotel’s rava onion dosas are already off the menu, along with parottas. In the next three days, if things do not improve, India’s favourite comfort food, ghee masala dosas will follow.

“If I remove dosa, sambar and coffee from the menu, it would cause more inconvenience to the public,” says Jegan S Damodarasamy, CEO, Annapoorna Hotels, adding however that dosas will not be available from 10.30am to 6pm, in an attempt to conserve fuel.

He adds, “When metro cities like Bengaluru have shut restaurants already, for tier II cities it is even more challenging... At this point, I am only praying. This is the first time in the 58 years we have been open that we have not served dosas in the afternoon.”

– With inputs from *Prabalika M Borah, S Poorvaja, K Jeshi, Barry Rodgers, and Nivedita Ganguly*



An art time capsule

Garden of Our Memories – I traces six decades of artistic friendships shaped by one of Chennai’s oldest galleries

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It is not every day that the works of Akkitham Narayanan, MF Husain, C Douglas and Achutan Kudallur share the same wall. At Garden of Our Memories - I, now showing at the Lalit Kala Akademi, Sarala’s Art Centre brings together nearly 200 paintings and sculptures by artists who have intersected with the gallery over its six-decade journey.

Founded in 1965 by Soli J Daruwala and Moti Daruwala,

Sarala’s Art Centre was among the first private galleries in South India dedicated to modern and contemporary art. The venture grew out of a framing business Soli established in Madras after working in the framing section of the Chemould Art Gallery in Bombay. Widely considered among the city’s first commercial framers, the Daruwalas soon expanded the space into a gallery.

At a time when cities like Bombay and Delhi were shaping the national discourse around Modernism, the gallery created a crucial platform in Madras for

Walk down nostalgia lane (Left) Garden of Our Memories - I at Lalit Kala Akademi; (below) Sarala Banerjee and Bishwajit Banerjee. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

artists experimenting with new visual languages and helped anchor the region’s emerging modern art movement.

According to Sarala Banerjee, daughter of Soli and Moti and the second-generation owner of Sarala’s Art Centre, students and practising artists from the Government College of Arts and Crafts, the country’s first art college, would often gravitate towards the modest



gallery space. “Art students and artists had no place to go to talk about contemporary art, so they would come to this little gallery and chat with my parents. That’s how the community grew,” she recalls.

Familial ties

The Daruwalas formed close ties with artists and teachers from the art college, including KCS Paniker, and the gallery soon evolved into a space where artists regularly congregated. Many struggling artists would even leave their paintings there and ask the Daruwalas for an advance when they needed money.

Sarala recalls that the city itself was a very different place then. “There was no idea of contemporary art in Madras those days,” she says. The cultural ecosystem around modern art was still taking shape. As the gallery grew, so did its circle of artists and patrons.

Sarala says many artists like MF Hussain, Suryaprakash, and Thota Tharani, who would later become prominent figures in the Indian contemporary art scene, were part of this early ecosystem. Her father, she notes, actively supported emerging artists of the Madras School building relationships that would endure as their careers

expanded. Garden of Our Memories - I reflects the gallery’s long history of those relationships.

“It’s just a few artists, the tip of the iceberg. We are trying to show a glimpse into what we actually have or hold or went through,” says Sarala. She describes the exhibition less as a curated survey and more as a gathering of memories.

For Sarala, the diversity of artists and styles is part of the exhibition’s appeal. Audiences approach art with very different sensibilities. Some are drawn to works for their aesthetic value, others for intellectual stimulation, while many collectors simply want something meaningful to live with in their homes. The exhibition, she says, reflects that wide spectrum of tastes.

This is only the first instalment, she notes, hinting at future shows that will draw from the gallery’s archives and relationships. For now, the display offers a small window into a much larger story – one shaped by generations of artists, friendships and shared histories.

Garden of Our Memories - I is on display at Lalit Kala Akademi until March 14. Entry is open to all.

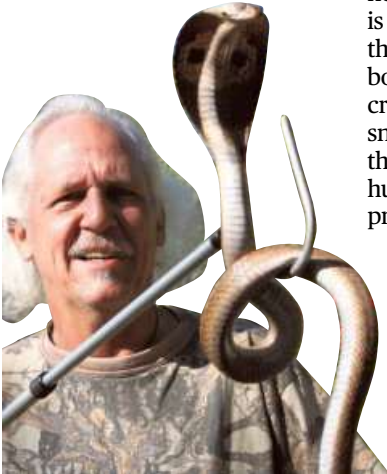
Zai and Rom Whitaker’s latest book for young readers, *The Book of Indian Snakes*, tackles common misconceptions surrounding these reptiles, highlighting their utility to humans

Snakes and the city

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When it comes to snakes, misconceptions are not far behind. At a college talk in Chennai by Zai Whitaker, a Biology teacher in the audience stood up and declared that she was convinced that snakes drink milk, recounts the writer, naturalist and teacher, who has recently co-authored a new book with the well-known herpetologist Romulus Whitaker – *The Book of Indian Snakes*, published by Juggernaut.

The same teacher also appeared to believe that rat snakes strike with their tails and that snake stones cure snakebites, she recalls. “In spite of the books, the articles, the conversations, these are deep-rooted beliefs,” says Zai, over a Zoom call.



The Book of Indian Snakes takes some of these myths head-on, stressing that while it is important to respect snakes, they should not be feared. The book also delves into the crucial ecosystem services snakes provide, highlighting their incredible utility to humans because their main prey are rodents. “A healthy snake population in the fields is a much better way to control rodents than the poisonous pesticides that cause so much harm to our environment and wildlife,” states the book, which goes on to answer many basic

Natural hiss-tories (Clockwise from left) Zai Whitaker; a spectacled cobra; vine snake; and Rom Whitaker. EMMANUAL YOGINI AND JANAKI LENIN

questions about snakes, such as the approximate number of species in India, their habitats, life histories, and venom information. The brain behind the structure of the book, says Zai, was the publisher Anita Mani, who runs the Indian Pitta book imprint in collaboration with Juggernaut Books. “Also, with my writing for children, it is becoming more and more obvious that the question-and-answer format works well. We focussed on the questions and information people have been seeking for the last 50 years,” she says. Rom, over the same Zoom call, adds, “The questions are usually very similar, and the parents hand them down to their kids. I’ve always said that while people’s attitude towards

snakes is often negative, they are fascinated (by them),” he says, pointing out that children, in particular, have a sense of wonder about these misunderstood creatures. The book, according to Rom, was an “exciting challenge” because he feels that it is not easy for people to understand snakes. “It takes a little while. I often say that they are creatures from Mars because we can’t relate to them in any way.”

Making it better Rom and Zai had collaborated earlier on another book about snakes for young readers, *The Snakes Around Us*. “It was a basic book for the National Book Trust, with some black-and-white pictures and drawings. We felt that it was time for a book with lots of colour pictures, good photography and printing so that it becomes easier for people to identify the snakes,” says Zai. Additionally, since the NBT book was published in the ‘80s, much has changed in our understanding of snakes. “For instance, so many more snakes have been discovered, the whole process and treatment of snakebite has changed, first-aid practices have changed... so, we thought it was important to update that

information as well,” she says. According to Rom, “as far as taxonomy is concerned, the study of speciation in snakes has grown by leaps and bounds.” While snakes did not receive much attention from biologists in the past, “nowdays you’ve got literally dozens of talented, mostly younger herpetologists. In the last 20 years since we came out with the first *Snakes of India* book in 2004, over 100 new species of snakes have been described, in part due to advances in molecular techniques.” Currently, biologists estimate that we have about 368 species of snakes in the country. But, Rom says, “that is a figure for today, not tomorrow because tomorrow there will be half-a-dozen more”.

Antivenom research is another field of study that has changed significantly since *The Snakes Around Us* was first published, an important development given that India is the world’s snakebite capital, representing about half of all global snakebite fatalities. Unfortunately, many Indians still prefer to go to local faith healers to treat snakebites, instead of going to a hospital or a primary healthcare centre. “In a majority of the cases, he (the faith healer) succeeds because a majority of snakebites are not fatal, but this works against us,” says Rom. It is important for people to realise that a snakebite is a medical emergency, he further adds. “There is only one treatment for snakebite, which is antivenom, and you need to go to the hospital right away.” Rom and Zai hope that this book will draw more children into learning about the natural world. “For children, the more wonder they accumulate about Nature, the better it is not just for conservation but also for their own mental health.” As COVID research has taught us, it is important to go outdoors,” believes Zai, adding that this has often been quoted as the benefit of having zoos. “Not only is it about the animals, but being outdoors in the greenery is definitely a part of it.”

A full score

City-based singer Cyril Simon Fernando on his journey from the pews of Luz church to the stage of Bulgaria’s State Opera Ruse

Susan Cherian

For many choristers, music remains a passion nurtured alongside everyday life. For a rare few, it becomes a calling that reshapes destiny. Cyril Simon Fernando belongs to the latter. An alumnus of Loyola College, Chennai, Simon has been selected as a bass singer with the State Opera Ruse, Bulgaria, a prestigious, State-funded cultural institution renowned for opera, ballet, and symphonic performances, and a cornerstone of the Bulgarian performing arts.

Simon’s musical journey began modestly as a tenor in a church choir. For years, this was his only musical ambition. However, a perceptive friend encouraged him to explore choral music, harmonies, and multiple voice parts. It was then that he discovered his natural strength as a bass while still retaining the ability to sing tenor.

This realisation led him to the choir of the Church of Our Lady of Light (Luz Church), where he sang regularly for nearly eight years, laying the spiritual and musical

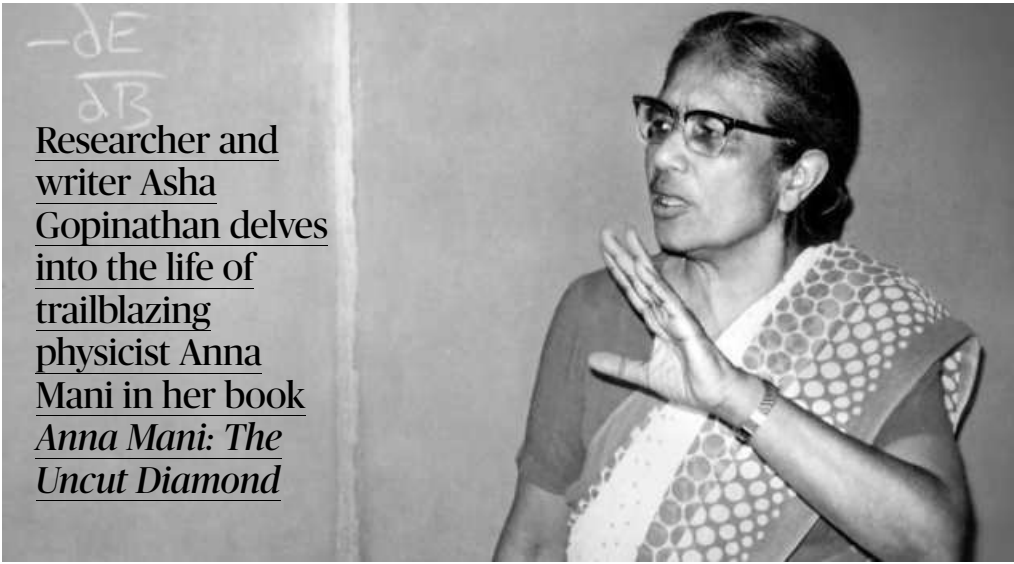
foundations of his journey. His first exposure to formal choral music came through the Indian Chorale Ensemble, a 40-member group blending Western choral harmonies with Indian musical elements, founded by singer-arranger Kalyani Nair and composer Karthik Manickavasakam. At the time, Simon had no formal training in music. A defining chapter came through his association with The Madras Musical Association (MMA), particularly during its concert tour of Poland. Encouraged by Augustine Paul, music director, MMA, Simon embraced the dramatic demands of opera. With the continued support of Augustine, Simon applied for international opportunities through Musical Chairs, a global platform connecting classical musicians with professional engagements. After successfully presenting some of opera’s most demanding arias during auditions, he earned his place with the State Opera Ruse.

In tune Cyril Simon Fernando. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Understanding your rights

A women’s month special titled, Know Your Rights, is being organised by Koffee & Kalavaram in collaboration with Backyard. The interactive session, led by legal professionals including Abinaya Mahendiran, Dhilshath Raihana S and Rohini Ravikumar, will explore legal protections for women in workplaces, relationships, public and online spaces. @ Backyard, Adyar. March 15, 4pm-6pm. Open to individuals identifying as women. Fee is ₹294. To register: 7358458117.



Researcher and writer Asha Gopinathan delves into the life of trailblazing physicist Anna Mani in her book *Anna Mani: The Uncut Diamond*

Forging a new path (Clockwise from left) Anna Mani; With MGK Menon and Radhakrishnan at her 75th birthday celebrations; and the new book. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND IITM PUNE



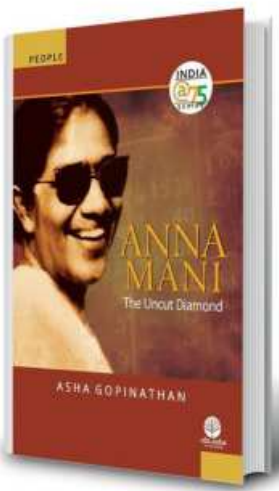
Scientific sparkle

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Researcher and writer Asha Gopinathan remembers asking children to name a female scientist when working on science popularisation programmes with the Alliance Francaise in Thiruvananthapuram in March 2015. After several moments of silence, a hand went up and a voice said ‘Marie Curie’. “I realised then that something was wrong. And this wrong needed to be corrected,” she adds. She also speaks of another instance from the past, when she asked children to draw scientists. “Thiruvananthapuram is a space town, so of course, space consoles and rockets featured across the drawings. But another thing I noticed was how all the scientists the children drew were men,” she recalls. Asha spent the next decade working on the book,

Anna Mani - The Uncut Diamond, published by the National Book Trust (NBT), Delhi, in 2025. A chronicle of the life of trailblazing physicist and renowned meteorologist Anna Mani, it chronicles the scientist’s journey from her birth in Peeramade, Idukki, her time at Women’s Christian College, Chennai as she finished her Intermediate years, her stint at scientist CV Raman’s laboratory as one of three women, her many years and expansive work at the India Meteorological Department, Pune where she retired as the Deputy Director-General, and her continuing work in the areas of atmospheric physics, ozone, radiation, and atmospheric electricity. “I didn’t think it would take me 10 years of my life,” says Asha, describing her work on the book. When she started a decade ago, she recalls having nothing else to go by except her scientific papers and two rare interviews that the physicist

had given. “I wrote the first five chapters based on this, and it was shaping up to be a very scientific-oriented book,” she says. This made her rethink her approach, and she headed to the Raman Research Institute in Bengaluru where Anna had served as a visiting professor. “People at the library there helped me with a lot of documentation and I also got to visit Anna’s flat where I discovered letters. As I



travelled more, I serendipitously began meeting people who had worked with her or knew her,” she says. Asha says this decade-long delve into Anna’s life might have been a complicated process, but getting in touch with many people for this has meant that they are now one big extended family. This approach which balances Anna’s life and her science is an exploration of the two worlds she traversed. “One was the world of a high flying scientist and the other was her time spent in workshops and labs which was very important. I met many of the older workers who worked with her and the book describes many of their experiences, because I feel that science is not just the activity of a few people who are highly intellectual, but it is the coming together of laboratory assistants and workers as well,” Asha says. “Anna had to balance both worlds to achieve the sort of science she pursued and every morning, she would spend a few hours in the workshops and only then would head to her office,” she adds. In Chennai in February to

launch the book at Women’s Christian College, where Anna studied from 1934 to 1936, Asha addressed students about Anna’s journey as one of the most important physicists of the country. Delving into how women and science education has grown in the same college, Asha points to an inscription at the college’s science building, which notes that it was built with the contributions from women in the United States. “In 1915, there were only three women out of 42 who took science. By 1920, half the college was taking up science and with the setting up of the new science building in 1925 things kept improving. Very soon, five women graduated with distinction in Physics,” she says. While Anna went to Presidency College from 1936 to 1939 to get her BSc Honours in Physics, she came back to WCC as a tutor. “This is where she always says she truly learned her Physics, always being in the laboratories and workshops building things,” Asha says. She left the students with one question: “Will Anna Mani become the scientist of your imagination?”

QUICK CROSSWORD #44
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Across

1 Form of Government (7)
5 Harass (5)
8 Bridge (7)
9 Sofa-cum-bed (5)
10 Kingdom (5)
11 Container for ashes (7)
12 Brief period (6)
14 Irritation (6)
17 Entertainment industry (4,3)
19 Beginning (5)
22 Book of Maps (5)
23 Tents (4-3)
24 Ludicrous act (5)
25 Person at random (7)

Down

1 Put off (5)
2 Sanctum sanctorum (5)
3 Stone Age dweller (4,3)
4 Wasteland herb (6)
5 Strikes (5)
6 Delay (3-4)
7 Old form of photo (7)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



Solution No. 44

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By 4.30pm, Mannady begins to shift gears. A narrow stretch of this North Chennai locality gathers momentum as popular restaurants set up temporary snack counters outside their premises. Massive cast-iron kadais sit over roaring flames, oil shimmering and ready, as batches of mutton and chicken samosas, chicken cutlets and pakoras and various other non-vegetarian snacks are slipped in and lifted out in quick, practised motions.

The air turns thick with the aroma of kebabs. As far as the eye can see, there are trays piled high with samosas, halwa, rose milk and colourful sherbats, glistening under tubelights. The stretch of uninterrupted iftar indulgence continues well after 8pm.

Mannady and candy chicken
“In this neighbourhood, iftar snacks were earlier sold just outside the mosque – mostly bajji, maasi vada, masal vada and chicken 65,” says Mohammed Mustansir, proprietor, Hatimys. “About a decade ago, we pioneered the concept of snack counters outside our restaurant exclusively for iftar. Since then, the culture has picked up,” he adds.

Today, his spread features nearly 30 varieties of snacks. This Ramzan, the new additions include Irani malai chicken, mutton China cheese kebab, mutton seekh in malai sauce, and a chicken tahini roll – all of which are crowd-pullers. “Since 2021, we’ve been seeing a surge in people thronging this area specifically to taste iftar snacks.” By sunset, Mannady is no longer just a trading hub – it becomes a destination.

After the azan

From Mannady’s bustling snack counters to curated iftar boxes and Ramzan buffets, Chennai’s iftar culture is blending tradition with innovation



At Firdous Sweets and Snacks, Mohamed Sadiq is busy assembling boxes filled with chicken cutlets, samosas, crab lollipops and their popular candy chicken, a local favourite that disappears almost as quickly as it is fried. The counter barely gets a pause. A few doors away, the makeshift stall outside Chettinase Fast Food draws a steady crowd. Here, chicken

lollipops and crisp chicken are bestsellers, lifted straight from bubbling oil and placed on paper plates. Nearby vendors line the pavement with steel containers of colourful sherbets and neat stacks of masal vada and paruppu vada, adding to a sense of festive excess. Mohammed’s iftar snacks are priced 15% lower during Ramzan,

Ramzan vignettes (Clockwise from left) Evening rush at Mannady as trays of samosas, cutlets and fried chicken beckon shoppers; at the Big Mosque; haleem counter at Abid’s and chefs from Kashmir showcase their cuisine at Noor-e-Ramzan. B JOTHI RAMALINGAM AND R RAVINDRAN



Boxing tradition

The snack counter at Abid’s, Spurtank Road turns into a seasonal institution every Ramzan, eagerly awaited by its loyal patrons. Proprietor Abid Zahir curates a special line-up of North Malabar delights, including chicken chatti pathiri, chemeen undaputtu (prawn balls), kaipola (steamed banana cake) and the traditional sweet unnakai. For seafood lovers, the spread extends to calamari fritters, fish and chips, and crumb-fried prawns. Among this year’s new launches are bun kebab, shawarma and the Turkish adana roll, adding a West Asian touch to the menu. Abid’s continues to draw crowds for its staples — fried chicken, samosas, cutlets, rolls and kebabs — along with hearty portions of mutton haleem and nombu kanji.

To order iftar snacks, call 9841284703.

At Shiraz Art Cafe, Ramzan takes on a Persian flavour with a specially curated iftar box featuring the creations of home chef Nasrin Karimi. Priced at ₹599, the takeaway box includes rose sherbet, mutton kobideh kebab, mutton gilla biryani, mint dip, chicken chello kebab, brinjal chutney, onion raita and a fruit truffle for dessert.

Orders must be pre-booked by 9am, with pick-up scheduled at 4.30pm from Nungambakkam. For bookings, call 9840572126.

Well-known wedding caterer Syed Suhail of Zaara Catering, who successfully organised the Iftar Mela last year, is expanding the concept this year with Daawat-e-Ramzan — a larger showcase of regional flavours from Hyderabad and Bengaluru. “We have 15 cooks from Hyderabad arriving in Chennai to prepare an elaborate iftar spread which includes a wide range of iftar snacks, seekh kebabs, biryanis, haleem and rich gravies. We’re also focussing on a variety of mutton dishes, and authentic Hyderabad desserts will be prepared fresh and served on-site,” says Syed. The event promises to bring the essence of Hyderabad’s Ramzan food culture to Chennai’s festive table.

Daawat-e-Ramzan is opposite Express Avenue, Royapettah, from 4pm to 11pm. With limited seating, takeaway is recommended.

Launched in 1962 in Alwarpet, Hotel Samco has long been known for its pocket-friendly iftar offerings. This year, the restaurant has expanded its Ramzan specials by introducing an iftar buffet alongside its popular takeaway box. Sadique Aboobacker says the box serves two. It includes fruits, sherbet, dates, shawarma, mandi, nombu kanji, parotta, chicken curry, mutton samosa, mutton haleem, BBQ chicken and gulab jamun.

The takeaway iftar box is priced at ₹649, and will be available at all six outlets from 4pm to 7pm. The iftar buffet is priced at ₹849 and will be open from 6pm to 8pm. To pre-book call 9745528080.

and after 7pm visitors to his stall can avail a buy-one-get-one offer. Those who throng these eateries rarely leave without something sweet to wash it down. Tall tumblers of chilled rose milk, silky caramel puddings and creamy custards are popular choices. And at Hatimys, the mango coconut pudding, biscoff pudding and custard cake have become a

must-have for the tropical sweetness offering the perfect finish to a spice-laden iftar spread. In Mannady, iftar is not a solitary ritual. It is a street-wide affair. Snacks are priced between ₹40 and ₹120. Shared food in Triplicane At the historic Wallajah Mosque, or the Big Mosque as it is popularly known, the spirit of Ramzan unfolds

in its most generous form. As the call to prayer approaches for iftar, thousands of people sit in rows, shoulder to shoulder on long sheets laid across the courtyard, ready to break their fast. What makes this meal special is not only the scale but the hands that help prepare it. About 70 Hindu volunteers of the Sufi Dar’s Trust in Mylapore prepare food in their central kitchen and transport it to the mosque by 4pm, and distribute the iftar eatables. The menu and the variety of items distributed depends on the donations recieved for that day. Puj Dada Ratanchand Ji, Sufi saint and founder of Sufi Dar, Mylapore, initiated this tradition over 40 years ago, and the trust has been doing this since, says his grandson Manish Hathiramani. Govind Bharwani one of the volunteers of the trust says “We distribute rose milk, banana, biscuits, dates, snacks, sweets, water and one variety rice, all through the Ramzan fasting days to over 1,200 people,” he says. When the azan echoes, the fast is broken together. Faith may differ, but food is shared.

Ramzan bazaar at YMCA grounds
If Mannady is intimate and Triplicane is steeped in tradition, then Noor-e-Ramzan is poised to be a full-blown celebration at the YMCA Grounds. Organised by Zaheer Basha, proprietor, Bombay Food Court, the event, which is being held for the first time, will transform the open grounds into a culinary map of India. Chefs from Kashmir, Delhi, Mumbai, Hyderabad and Madurai are setting up stalls to showcase their regional Ramzan fare, bringing together flavours rarely found in one place. “We are bringing in 10 chefs from Kashmir to showcase their wazwan dishes. From Hyderabad, we will have haleem and zafrani biryani. The Delhi counter will focus exclusively on mohabbat ka sherbat – a drink made with milk, rose syrup, watermelon chunks and sugar. Mumbai’s stall will serve iftar snacks like candy chicken, kebabs and rolls, while the Madurai chefs will spotlight parotta and chicken curry,” says Zaheer.

Beyond Indian regional cuisines, there will also be an international counter where visitors can try Dubai shawarma cake and kunafa, Italian lasagna, Turkish ice cream, a range of Lebanese desserts and Kashmiri pink tea. The festival extends beyond food. Stalls selling décor, leather goods, textiles and fashion accessories aim to recreate the atmosphere of a festive Ramzan bazaar.

STEP OUT



heritage. Each artwork is positioned not merely as an object of display, but as a living narrative that reflects history, community and individual voice. Native Krea is located at Ekkattuthangal. Open on all days between 10am and 7pm. For enquiries, call 9791774321.

Native narratives take centrestage
Native Krea, a city-based gallery, has been founded with the aim of reviving, redefining and reimagining Indian artistic traditions. The gallery collaborates with native artists whose practices are rooted in cultural memory, folklore and traditional visual languages, while also engaging with present-day themes and experiences. Figurative narratives, vibrant colour palettes and storytelling form the core of its exhibitions, bringing to life visual expressions inspired by literary and artistic



Songs and stories with Ziskakan
Music lovers in the city can look forward to an evening of live music and storytelling as ProMusicals and Focusrite present Scarlett Nights – Edition #2 featuring Ziskakan. Titled Ziskakan Live: Songs & Stories, the concert blends music and narratives reflecting the band’s style. The event is organised in collaboration with Alliance Française of Madras, Nungambakkam, March 13, 7.30pm. Entry is free with prior registration. For details, call 9841186951.

Movie music by candlelight

Two candlelight concerts celebrating film music will be presented as part of the Candlelight series. Best Movie Soundtracks will feature flute by JA Jayant and team in an intimate setting. Tribute to AR Rahman will be performed by Hues & Harmonies - The Indian Bamboo Flute Project, celebrating the music of AR Rahman. Each concert will run for 60 minutes and tickets are priced from ₹999 onwards. @ The Leela Palace, March 15. The first show is at 6pm and, the second at 8.30pm. Tickets at liveyourcity.com

We love the ‘70s

A musical tribute to the golden era of Hindi cinema will be presented by Satrangi with its upcoming programme We Love 70s. The concert will revisit memorable songs from popular 1970s films such as Julie, Mere Jeevan Saathi, Kabhi Kabhie, Yaadon Ki Baaraat, Anamika, Caravan, Hare Rama Hare Krishna, Anand and Jawani Diwani. The programme will be presented by Promod, Smriti, Abhishek and Ramya, accompanied by a live orchestra. @Chinmaya Heritage Centre, Chetpet. March 15, 6pm onwards. For tickets, priced at ₹1,000, ₹600 and ₹300, call 9884778073.

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Riding the K-Wave
A still from *Made In Korea*; (below) Priyanka Mohan. NETFLIX

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For Shenba, the protagonist in Netflix's *Made In Korea*, South Korea is a faraway, fantastical land. She is fascinated by its history, and its K-Pop and K-Dramas of course, and initially believes a train from her town will lead her there. As she grows up, the fascination and yearning to visit this country she declares her favourite only grows.

In a first-of-its-kind Tamil-Korean collaboration by Netflix, *Made In Korea* has actor Priyanka Arul Mohan take on the role of earnest, wide-eyed Shenba who finds herself in the Land of Morning Calm, propelled by a mix of family and relationship drama. For the actor who made her debut in 2019 and has since gone onto star in Telugu, Tamil and Kannada films, this film marks a milestone; as the first film where she takes the reins as the lead.

Ahead of the film's release, Priyanka and director Ra Karthik, during a virtual interview, have much to say about their experiences in Seoul, and filming this cross-cultural project.

Seoul searching

Priyanka Arul Mohan and director Ra Karthik take us through *Made In Korea* and how the film proved to be a journey of discovery

"I did not feel like this was a challenge," says Priyanka, when asked how she approached the role of Shenba. "I have been waiting for stories like this for a long time, and after it came to me, my thoughts were on how to do justice to the role. I wanted to be more of myself here," she says.

Homeward bound
The proliferation of the KWave and the immense popularity of all things K-Culture is something that piqued director Ra Karthik's curiosity. "It got me wondering about how immersed people are in this

world; how they love Lee Min Ho like their superstar. I began to think of what South Korea would be like, to people like this who finally make it there. Once I got this idea, I

started scripting the film," he says.

The romance of a new city aside, *Made In Korea* does not limit itself to love and grounds Shenba's story in self-discovery, something Karthik says was a conscious writing choice. "I was certain I didn't want the romance people had already seen in several K-Dramas. My target audience is people who love K-Dramas and K-Pop and I wanted to connect with them on a shared aspiration of being able to visit South Korea. I decided to make it about a woman, and explore both the fantasy and the realities of this dream, and

have her journey through human values rather than romance," he explains. Karthik recalls landing in Seoul a week prior to Priyanka and the crew joining him there. "I was alone and had to navigate how to catch a cab from the airport, taking the bus, and a host of other things that feature in the film as well. All of this wasn't born out of research but my own experiences there. I realised I wanted Shenba to experience this in the film as well," he explains.

Priyanka, whose first time it was in Seoul as well, chimes in. "The team also was like Shenba; we were learning so much, and discovering something every single day through our one-and-a-half months of filming there. For me, it was an immersive experience into the culture, people, food, emotions and values of the country."

While we are initially introduced to Shenba in her picturesque hilly hometown in Tamil Nadu, the film soon moves her to Seoul and her life there becomes populated with a bevy of locals, played by a host of Korean actors including actor Park Hye-jin who was most notably, also seen in *Squid Game* as Cho Sang-woo's (played by actor Park Hae-soo) mother.

The actor, who was last seen in the Telugu film *They Call Him OG* opposite Pawan Kalyan has a fantasy rom-com with actor Kavin in the works, as well as the Kannada film *666 Operation Dream Theatre* coming up for release. "We shot *Made In Korea* last year and I feel like I was transformed, in a way. The film ensured I did not restrict myself and encouraged me to think broader. The experience of working on this film has given me the confidence of working on different stories going forward," she says.

The work hours might have been rigorous on this project but for Priyanka, the film, she says, was an experience to cherish. "I went to bed at peace everyday, and I feel like I have carried this forward to every film I have worked on since. I am really having fun," she smiles.

Made In Korea is now streaming on Netflix



I have been waiting for stories like this for a long time, and after it came to me, my thoughts were on how to do justice to the role

PRIYANKA MOHAN
Actor



Newspaper trails

Tamil comedy-drama series, *Local Times* will release on March 13. Directed by Naveen George Thomas, the show stars Rishikanth, Abdool Lee, Maurish Dass, Adwitha Arumugam, R Pandiarajan, Chinni Jayanth, Rini, and Nandhitha Sreekumar in pivotal roles. The series tells the story of four friends — Veera, Azhagu, Valli, and Muthu,

who are determined to keep the legacy of *Namma Seidhi*, a once-respected regional newspaper owned by Veera's grandfather, alive. The trailer offers a glimpse into the chaotic lives of this motley crew, their hilarious misadventures, unexpected wins, a powerful nemesis who is hellbent on taking them down, and their admirable bond of friendship that refuses to collapse, even when everything else does.



A gangster returns

Thiagarajan Kumararaja's debut movie *Aaranya Kaandam* is set for re-release on March 13. Produced by playback singer and actor SP Charan, the Tamil movie first released on June 10, 2011. "Some films don't age. They become cult classics," Charan, son of legendary singer SP Balasubrahmanyam, posted on social media, announcing the re-release date. A neo-noir film with a strong presence of dark humour, the movie stars Ravi Krishna, Jackie Shroff, Sampath Raj, Yasmin Ponnappa and Guru Somasundaram. with music by Yuvan Shankar Raja and cinematography by PS Vinod.

Game on!

The open-world mobile game, *Vilayath Budha: The Sandalwood Survival*, features actor Prithviraj



World building The Offline Human Studios team; (below) the interface of the game inspired by *Vilayath Budha*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Vilayath Budha: The Sandalwood Survival, an open-world mobile game released in February, has many firsts to its credit. Not only is it possibly India's first movie-inspired open-world game (for mobiles), it is also a first-of-its-kind collaboration between a production house, Urvasi Theatres, and gaming company, Offline Human Studios. It also features Prithviraj Sukumaran, one of the first actors from South India in a game such as this.

The Malayalam film *Vilayath Budha*, released in 2025 based on the eponymous novel by GR Indugopan, is about a sandalwood smuggler Double Mohanan, his mentor, Bhaskaran Master and a sandalwood tree, Vilayath Budha. Prithviraj essays Mohanan.

Karthik Suresh, one of the co-founders of Offline Human Studios, says, "We are attempting something different with the game Vilayath Budha. There is a perception that this is a promotion for the film. It is not. Usually, games are released around a film's release, like recently for *Chatha Pacha*. But not our game."

The film was released in November 2025, while the early access to the game (for downloads) was opened only in the first week of February 2026. However, it has been in the works for more than six months.

Offroading-based game
Offline Human Studios wanted to create a game around a familiar title that

would not only have recall, as in this case, but also build a world around it. It helped that they were also looking forward to making an off-roading-based game. Since the film was shot mostly in Marayoor, Idukki, they could showcase the lush natural beauty of Kerala.

Karthik explains, "With an open world game we can create a world which a gamer can explore, they can go anywhere in the universe of the game. The world is open to you to explore, in Vilayath Budha you can do it in the jeep which is also a character in the film."

Profit share with producers

It could get difficult convincing a producer about the idea, but Urvasi Theatres were on board from the get-go, he adds. Offline Human Studios has a profit-share agreement with Urvasi Theatres. They also have the IP (Intellectual



Property) consent to use the title of the book, Prithviraj's face and assets from the film.

Rather than release the game, Karthik says, they chose to give early access so that gamers could experience it and give their feedback about what they would like in the next update. When it is released later this year, it will come out with a complete storyline, the access for now permits 'exploration' of smaller spaces and not the entire universe of the game.

Having Prithviraj in the game helps the game because the actor has a pan-India appeal. Say Karthik "Those accessing the game may not know the character, Double Mohanan, but they know Prithviraj, and that adds a curiosity factor."

Twists and thrills

Park Min-young and Wi Ha-joon discuss essaying diverse characters in the romantic thriller *Siren's Kiss*

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When we meet South Korean actors Park Min-young and Wi Ha-joon for a virtual roundtable interaction ahead of the release of their upcoming K-drama *Siren's Kiss*, the stars are all smiles and full of banter. This seems to be a far cry from what we think is in store for us in the high-stakes romance thriller, perhaps there are twists that await?

The show, which is all set to stream on Prime Video from March 2, follows Cha Woo-seok (Wi Ha-joon), an ace

investigator who delves into an insurance fraud scheme linked to a series of mysterious deaths. It isn't long before he becomes entangled with Han Seol-ah (Park Min-young), an art auctioneer who seems to be at the centre of it all. She comes with a dangerous past; every man who has ever loved her has died, and as Woo-seok begins to investigate, what follows is romance, suspense, and of course, many more secrets. Both actors have a track record of compelling onscreen pairings in their past K-dramas and their pairing in this show has fans anticipating crackling chemistry from the get-go.



For K-drama royalty Park Min-young, whose acting credits span shows across several genres, *Siren's Kiss* was a subject that she found deeply fascinating. "I had never tried a character along these lines, with this kind of vibe, before. So I was really curious to see how it would feel to bring this character to life, and how it

would be received by the audience," she says. "I decided to take on this character, considering it a new challenge, and I think it will be the first time I don't smile, not even once throughout the entire series," the actor adds, laughing.

Ha-joon, who was last seen in the final season of the global

hit *Squid Game*, says that while he has played similar characters in the past, he thought Woo-seok from *Siren's Kiss* was different, given his diverse emotions. "He can be cold, charismatic, suave, cute, adorable, and very heartwarming at the same time. I considered this a new challenge," he says.

Mysteries abound Park Min-young and Wi Ha-joon in a still from *Siren's Kiss*. PRIME VIDEO

Having starred in the hit show, fantasy revenge drama *Marry My Husband* and more recently, in the crime comedy *Confidence Queen*, a mystery thriller like *Siren's Kiss*, Min-young says, is something she has always wanted to try.

For many who began watching K-dramas during the COVID-19 pandemic, Min-young's romance shows, including *Her Private Life* and *What's Wrong With Secretary Kim*, featured highly on watchlists. While her role in 2011's *City Hunter* opposite Lee Min-ho did require her to perform stunts, she hopes to star in a full-blown action show soon.

"But I'd need to build some of my stamina back to take on that kind of intense action, because right now, in order to portray Seol-ah, I haven't worked out for quite some time and have lost some weight," she says. "But one day, I'd really love to pull off some fierce, intense action. I

have really small fists, and people always tease me about that, but I'd love to show them what a powerful punch I can throw," the actor adds, miming throwing a punch at her co-star Ha-joon.

Keeping with the theme of the show, Min-young and Ha-joon reveal some of their mysterious traits in real life, something their fans do not know about. "As much as I like watching dramas and films, I also love watching crime documentaries and sports shows. Especially *F1*; I love speed," Min-young says. Ha-joon, meanwhile, professes his love for a specific genre of music. "I love listening to sentimental songs," he says.

When asked about the one thing they hope audiences and fans will love about *Siren's Kiss*, Min-young jokes and says people will be shocked to see that she has a cold side to her, and that Ha-joon is that handsome. "I also hope that people think we deserve the best couple award," Ha-joon adds.

Siren's Kiss is streaming on Prime Video